THE PENCIL SHARPENER

ALSO BY MICHAEL SHUN McLAURIN

The McLearn Media Series

Book One · McLearn Media

Book Two · The Accidental Executive

Book Three · The Highway 80 Ledger

Book Four · The Master's Hand

THE PENCIL SHARPENER

A McLearn Media Story

A Novel

MICHAEL SHUN McLAURIN

McLEARN MEDIA

Brandon, Mississippi

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Published by McLearn Media, an imprint of McLearn LLC, Brandon, Mississippi.

A free story from the world of the McLearn Media series: McLearn Media · The Accidental Executive · The Highway 80 Ledger · The Master's Hand.

First edition · 2026

For every teacher who saw what a child's hands were for,
and said so.

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Chapter One
THE BACK TABLE

The pencil sharpener in Room 11 at Brandon Elementary had been broken since the Fourth of July, and everybody in the fourth grade knew whose fault it was, and nobody would say.

It was a Boston, the gray kind with the hand crank and the little drawer underneath that pulled out to empty, screwed to the wall beside the door at the height of a ten-year-old's shoulder. Over the summer somebody from summer school had fed it a whole red crayon, paper and all, and then a green one to see what would happen, and what happened was that it stopped. You could turn the crank, but it didn't catch anything. It made a dry, gritty noise like a man walking on a gravel drive, and the pencil came back out of the hole exactly the way it went in, only sadder.

Mrs. Horton had put in a work order with the district office. A man had come on the second Tuesday of September with a gray metal case and a clipboard, and had taken the sharpener off the wall and looked into it for some time, and had put it back on the wall and written something on the clipboard and gone away. A second man came the week after and did the same thing, only quicker. Nobody came the week after that. Mrs. Horton kept a coffee can of pencils on her desk that she sharpened at home every night with a kitchen knife over the trash can, and the class used those, and the sharpener hung on the wall by the door like a picture of somebody who had died.

Marcus Jennings could not stop looking at it.

He was eight years old that September, nine in October, and he sat in the third row by the window, where Mrs. Horton had put him on the first day because the window was where the light was, and because, she said, a boy ought to have something to

look at besides the back of Tonya Rankin's head. He did not look out the window much. He looked at the sharpener. He looked at the screws that held it to the wall, two of them, slotted, painted over once with the wall so that the slots had paint in them. He looked at the crank and the way it stuck out at an angle when it was let go, and he thought about what was in there, and what it looked like, and what a crayon would do to it, and whether it could be got out, and he did not think about long division, which was what was on the board.

He did not mean to not think about long division. That was the thing nobody understood. He meant to. He sat down every morning meaning to. And then his foot started, and then his knee started, and then his hands found something, and by the time Mrs. Horton got to the second problem he would be holding a ballpoint pen in four pieces, the spring and the barrel and the cap and the little ink tube, and he would not be able to say for certain how it had gotten that way.

"Marcus."

"Ma'am."

"What's in your hands?"

He looked down. A pen. In pieces. "A pen."

"Is it your pen?"

He thought about it. "It's Dwayne's."

Dwayne Lofton, in the seat behind him, said, "Hey," in the voice of somebody finding out a thing about himself at the same time as everybody else.

"Put it back together, please, and give it back to Dwayne," Mrs. Horton said, "and then I'd like you to look at the board."

He put it back together. It took about four seconds. He gave it back to Dwayne. He looked at the board. The long division sat up there in Mrs. Horton's big round chalk and meant nothing to him at all, not because he couldn't do it, but because it wasn't anything. It was numbers that stood for other numbers. You couldn't open it up. You couldn't see what was wrong with it.

His foot started.

⁂

He had been in trouble in the third grade. He had been in trouble in the second grade too, a little, but the third grade was the year it got a name. The third grade teacher was a woman named

Mrs. Pruitt who wore her glasses on a chain and had been teaching third grade, she told the class on the first day, since before any of their parents were born, and she said it like it was a thing they owed her for. Mrs. Pruitt said Marcus had *ants in his pants*, and then she said he had *a motor*, and then around Christmas she started saying, to other teachers in the hall, where he could hear her, *the Jennings boy*, and then a little later, *well, you know about the daddy*, and the other teacher would say *oh, I know*, and they'd both look at him for a second the way you look at a dog that's been hit and is still walking.

He did not know what they knew about his daddy that he did not. He knew his daddy was gone. He knew it had been raining. He knew the truck had gone off Highway 80 east of Pearl in November two years ago, on a Monday, and that two men had come up the drive that evening in the rain, a state trooper and a preacher, and that his mama had stood at the kitchen sink with her hands on the edge of it and watched them come and had not moved until the second knock. That was what there was to know. If there was more, nobody was telling it to him, and he was not going to ask Mrs. Pruitt.

Mrs. Pruitt sent him to the office eleven times. He counted. He sat on the bench outside the principal's door eleven times with his hands under his legs to keep them still, and the secretary, a heavy woman named Mrs. Sumrall who smelled like cough drops, would look at him over her typewriter and shake her head, not at him exactly, and go back to typing. The eleventh time, she gave him a broken stapler out of her drawer and let him take it apart on the bench, and he had it back together and working before the principal ever opened the door, and Mrs. Sumrall looked at the stapler and then at him and said, "Well, I'll be," and kept it in her drawer after that, and every time he came by after that she said, "How's my stapler man," and he liked her better than anybody in the building.

Then it was summer, and then it was the fourth grade, and the fourth grade was Mrs. Horton.

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Delores Horton was thirty-six years old that year and had been teaching fourth grade at Brandon Elementary for eight of them. She was not tall and not short. She wore her hair pinned back and

her sleeves rolled to the elbow by ten in the morning, and she had a voice that did not go up. That was the first thing Marcus noticed about her. Every grown person he had ever been in trouble with had a voice that went up, higher and higher, until it came out at the top in a kind of shriek, and you could tell how much trouble you were in by how high it went. Mrs. Horton's voice did not do that. It went down. When she was pleased it was regular, and when she was not pleased it got lower and slower and quieter, so that the whole room leaned in to hear it, and by the time it was all the way down at the bottom, nobody in the room was breathing.

She also read out loud.

Every day after lunch, while the room was still warm and full of the smell of the cafeteria, Mrs. Horton sat on the corner of her desk with one foot on the chair and read to them for twenty minutes out of a real book, a chapter book, with no pictures. The first week it was *Where the Red Fern Grows*. She did not do voices, exactly. She just read it like she meant it. And Marcus, who could not sit still for long division or for spelling or for the Pledge of Allegiance, found out on the third day that he could sit still for this, mostly, if he had something in his hands. He could not have explained it. It was as if the part of him that needed to move, and the part of him that needed to listen, could not both be fed at once, and when one of them was eating the other one would go quiet.

So he took apart Dwayne's pen during *Where the Red Fern Grows* too. But he heard every word. When Old Dan got hurt, he stopped with the spring in his fingers and did not move for a whole page, and Mrs. Horton saw that, though he did not know she saw it.

⁂

The thing happened on the last Thursday in September.

It was spelling, and spelling was the worst. Spelling was twenty words on the board that you had to copy three times each into your Blue Horse notebook, and the words did not mean anything together, they were just words that happened to have the same trouble in them, *receive* and *believe* and *ceiling*, and by the second time through *ceiling* his foot was going so hard that the whole desk was walking. It walked about four inches toward

the window. Tonya Rankin turned around in her seat and looked at him the way she always did, like he was something on the bottom of her shoe, and said, loud enough, "Mrs. Horton, Marcus is doing it again."

The room went quiet.

Mrs. Horton put the chalk down in the tray. She looked at Marcus. She looked at the desk, four inches out of line with all the other desks. She looked at the window, and then, for no reason that anybody in the room could see, she looked at the pencil sharpener.

Then she went to her desk and opened the bottom drawer, the deep one, where she kept her pocketbook, and took out a screwdriver.

It was a regular screwdriver, a flat one, with a yellow handle gone soft and brown where a hand had held it a long time. Marcus would find out later that it had been her daddy's, and that she kept it in her pocketbook the way some women kept a pistol, because a woman alone had things that needed tightening. She did not say any of that then. She walked to the door with the screwdriver in her hand, while twenty-six fourth graders watched her the way you watch somebody climb a ladder, and she took the pencil sharpener off the wall.

It took her a while. The paint had got in the slots. She had to scrape the first screw clean with the corner of the blade before the screwdriver would catch, and she leaned into it with her shoulder, and nobody said a word, and the screw came out with a little shriek. Then the second one. Then she held the sharpener in both hands, gray and heavy and full of somebody else's red and green crayon, and walked it to the back of the room and set it down on the back table, the long one by the coat hooks where they did projects, on a sheet of newspaper she pulled off the stack.

She laid the screwdriver down beside it.

"Marcus," she said. Her voice did not go up. "Come here, please."

He came. He did not know what it was. He thought maybe this was a new thing that was worse than the office.

Mrs. Horton put her hand on the sharpener, flat, the way you put your hand on a dog to tell it to stay.

"This has been broken since summer," she said. "Two men from the district have looked at it and neither one of them could make it go. I would like you to see if you can get it going."

He looked at her. He looked at the sharpener.

"If you can't," she said, "that's fine. Nobody else could either. And if you break it worse, well." She lifted her hand off it. "It was already broken. Do you understand me?"

He understood her. He did not believe her, quite, but he understood her.

"Yes ma'am."

"You may sit back here during spelling," she said, "and during reading, as long as you're listening to the reading. You may not sit back here during arithmetic. Arithmetic you will do with the rest of us, because you are going to need it, and I'm not going to let you not have it." She looked at him a second longer. "And when you take a thing apart, Marcus, you lay the pieces down in the order they came off. That's the only rule. You hear me?"

"Yes ma'am."

She went back up to the front of the room and picked up the chalk.

"*Ceiling*," she said to the class. "C-E-I. Who can tell me why?"

Tonya Rankin raised her hand, and Mrs. Horton called on her, and Marcus Jennings sat down at the back table in front of the broken pencil sharpener, and for the first time in two years he did not have to hide what his hands were doing.

⁂

He did not touch it at first.

He looked at it. That was the first thing. He sat with his hands in his lap and looked at it from every side, the way you walk around a car before you get in it, and he found the two screws on the bottom that held the drawer track, and the pin that held the crank, and the seam down the side where the housing came apart, and the little round plate on the front with the holes in it for different pencils that you turned to pick the size. He looked at it for so long that Mrs. Horton glanced back twice to see if he was all right. He was all right. He was more all right than he had been in a long time. He just did not want to start until he could see the whole thing in his head.

Then he picked up the screwdriver.

The crank came off first. There was a tiny pin through the hub, and he had to push it out with the tip of the screwdriver, a little at a time, and when it came it jumped and went off the table. He got down on the floor and found it under the coat hooks, by somebody's lunch box, and he laid it on the newspaper at the far left end. Then the crank, next to it. Then he turned the sharpener over, and took out the two screws on the bottom, and laid them down next, side by side. Then the drawer. Then he worked at the seam with the flat of the blade, and the housing came apart into two gray halves like a clamshell, and there it was.

The inside of a pencil sharpener is two cutters. He had not known that. He had thought, if he thought about it at all, that it would be a blade, like a knife, but it was two little steel rollers with spiral ridges cut into them, set at an angle to each other in a frame, and when you turned the crank the whole frame went around and the rollers went around too, each on its own pin, and the ridges ate the wood of the pencil down into a point. It was beautiful. He sat there and looked at it. The rollers were packed solid with red and green wax, every ridge full of it, all the way down, so that they were not rollers with ridges anymore but just smooth fat red-and-green cylinders, and nothing could catch on them, and the pencil went in and came out again with nothing happening to it at all.

That was all it was. That was the whole problem. It was not broken. It was full.

He wanted to laugh. He did not, because it was spelling, and Mrs. Horton was saying *receive* in her low voice up front. But he put his hand over his mouth and sat there with his shoulders shaking, and Dwayne Lofton turned all the way around in his desk to look at him, and Marcus took his hand down and pointed into the sharpener, and Dwayne leaned out into the aisle and looked, and did not understand at all, and Marcus did not care.

Two men from the district had looked at that. They had looked at the outside. Neither one of them had taken it apart.

⁂

He took the cutter frame out at reading time, while Mrs. Horton read the part where Billy finds the red fern. It came out with a C-clip on the shaft that he had to work at for most of a chapter with

the tip of the screwdriver and his thumbnail, and when it came off it flew too, and hit the window, and Mrs. Horton stopped reading and looked back, and he held up the C-clip so she could see it, and she nodded and kept reading. He laid it down on the newspaper. Then the frame. Then he worked the first roller off its pin, and the second, and set them side by side at the end of the line, two little red-and-green logs, and he looked down at the newspaper and there it all was, the whole sharpener, from left to right, in the order it came off. Pin. Crank. Two screws. Drawer. Two halves of the housing. C-clip. Frame. Two pins. Two rollers.

He would not have been able to tell anybody why it mattered that it was in order. It just did. Laid out like that, it wasn't a broken thing anymore. It was a sentence. You could read it backward, and that was how you'd put it back together.

The bell rang. He did not hear it. Mrs. Horton came down the aisle while the class was getting their lunch boxes and stood beside the back table and looked down at the newspaper for a long time.

"Huh," she said.

"It's full of crayon," Marcus said. "That's all. It ain't broke."

"Isn't."

"Isn't broke."

She looked at the two rollers, solid red and green. "Can you get it out?"

"I don't know yet." He thought about it. "I need something littler than this." He meant the screwdriver. "Something with a point. To get in the grooves."

"Like what?"

He knew exactly like what. It was in a toolbox in the hall closet at his house on Sherwood Drive, behind the vacuum cleaner and his mama's winter coat, in the top tray on the left, a little pick with a red wooden handle and a bent steel point that his daddy had used for getting the old gasket off a thermostat housing, and it was the exact right thing, and he could see it, and he did not say so.

"Something with a point," he said.

⁂

The toolbox had his name on the lid.

His daddy had painted it at the shop on Christmas Eve when Marcus was six, in white enamel, in block capitals, MARCUS ALTON JENNINGS, the whole thing, every letter, because his daddy said a thing a man was going to keep ought to have his whole name on it. It was a real one, red steel, with a tray that lifted out, and real tools in it that his daddy had picked out one at a time, and Marcus had slept with it at the foot of his bed for the whole rest of that winter, and taken it everywhere, and wanted to take it to school.

And then there had been a Monday, in November, when it was raining, and he had wanted to take it to school for show-and-tell, and his mama had said *toolbox stays home*, twice, the second time gentler. And it had stayed home. And that was the day.

He had not opened it since. Not once. It lived in the hall closet now, behind the coat and the vacuum cleaner, where his mama had put it at some point in that winter without either of them saying anything about it, and he knew exactly where it was every minute of every day, the way you know where a hole in the floor is in a dark house. He walked around it. He did not open the closet if he could help it. When his mama sent him for the broom, he got it without looking down.

Nobody had said it was a rule. It just was one. *Toolbox stays home.* And then, after a while, without anybody deciding it, *toolbox stays closed*.

⁂

His mama got home at five-forty. She worked the line at the fabrication plant off Highway 80, which meant she stood in one place for eight hours running a press that stamped out the same steel bracket over and over, and when she came in the door she smelled like hot metal and the pink soap from the plant bathroom, and she did not sit down. She never sat down when she first came in. She said, the year after, that if she sat down she would not get back up. So she came in the door and set her pocketbook on the counter and turned on the stove and started supper, and while supper went she pulled the ironing board out of the pantry and set it up in the kitchen and started on somebody's shirts.

She had started taking in ironing that summer, after the Ford went out. Marcus knew what the ironing was for, the way he

knew what everything in the house was for: the Ford was fixed now, and the ironing had not stopped, which meant the Ford had cost more than the ironing had brought in so far, and the ironing would go on until it caught up. There were always shirts. White ones, mostly, men's dress shirts from the doctors' wives on the other side of town, in a laundry basket by the back door, and they came in wrinkled and went out stiff on wire hangers, and his mama charged a quarter a shirt and did them faster than anybody he had ever seen do anything.

He sat at the kitchen table and did his arithmetic while she ironed, because she made him, and because arithmetic was the thing Mrs. Horton said he was going to need. He got through it. It was long division and it did not mean anything and he got through it anyway. Then he sat there.

His mama ironed a collar. She ironed a yoke. She hung the shirt on the doorknob of the pantry and took the next one out of the basket and snapped it once in the air, hard, the way she did, so the wrinkles jumped.

"Something on your mind," she said. Not a question.

"No ma'am."

"Mm." She laid the shirt down. Sleeve. Cuff. "Mrs. Horton call me today?"

He looked up, alarmed. "No ma'am."

"Then why you sitting there like she did?"

He did not know how to say it. He did not know how to start. He sat there with his pencil and his foot started going under the table, and he made it stop with his other foot, and it started again.

"She gave me a job," he said finally.

His mama stopped with the iron in the air. "A job."

"The pencil sharpener's broke. It's been broke since summer. Two men from the district looked at it and they couldn't fix it, and she took it off the wall with a screwdriver out of her pocketbook and she put it on the back table and she said, Marcus, see if you can get it going."

His mama set the iron down on its heel.

"And did you?"

"I took it apart." He could hear his own voice going faster. "It ain't broke. It isn't. It's full of crayon, somebody put crayon in it, a whole red one and a green one, and it's all down in the grooves, and that's all it is, and I can get it out, I know I can, but I need something littler than a screwdriver. Something with a point."

His mama looked at him for a long time.

She was thirty-five years old that year. She had been a widow for twenty-two months. She did not cry in front of him and she did not stand still if she could help it, and she ran a press all day and ironed doctors' shirts all night, and she had a way of looking at a thing until she understood all of it, even the part you were not saying, and then deciding whether to say that she understood. He watched her look at him. He watched her understand the part he was not saying. He watched her decide.

She did not say anything about the closet.

She turned the iron off at the wall, and she unplugged it, and she wrapped the cord around the handle the way she did when she was done for the night, even though there were still eleven shirts in the basket.

"Go wash up for supper," she said.

⁂

He found it after supper, when he went to his room.

It was sitting on his bed. The red toolbox, with the white letters on the lid, MARCUS ALTON JENNINGS, square in the middle of the bedspread where his mama had put it while he was washing up. She had not called him to come see it. She had not said anything at all. She was in the kitchen running the dishwater, and the radio was on low, and when he came to the door of his room and saw it there, he stood in the doorway and did not go in for a long time.

Then he went in, and sat on the bed beside it, and put his hand flat on the lid. The paint was a little rough under his palm where the brush had gone over it twice on the *J*.

He opened it.

It smelled like the shop. That was the first thing. It smelled like his daddy's shop, the oil and the cold steel and the faint sweet smell of the hand cleaner, the orange kind with the grit in it, and the smell came up out of the box all at once like it had been waiting, and Marcus sat there on the edge of the bed with his hand on the open lid and his eyes shut, and he did not cry, exactly, but something went through him that was the next thing over from crying, and he let it.

Then he opened his eyes and lifted out the tray.

Everything was where it had been. Two years, and nothing had moved, because nobody had moved it. The big screwdriver and the little one. The pliers. The adjustable wrench, too big for his hand when his daddy gave it to him and almost right for his hand now. The tape measure. The little hammer. And in the top tray, on the left, where he had known it would be, the pick with the red wooden handle and the bent steel point.

He picked it up. He turned it over. It was smaller than he remembered, and his hand was bigger.

Down the hall the dishwater ran, and stopped, and ran again. The radio played a song he did not know. Marcus Jennings sat on the edge of his bed with his daddy's pick in his hand and the toolbox open beside him, and he looked at the lid, at his own whole name in his daddy's white enamel, and he thought: *a thing a man is going to keep*.

Then he put the pick back in the tray, exactly where it came from, and closed the lid, and set the toolbox on the floor beside his bed, where it used to live.

In the morning, without either of them saying a word about it, he carried it out to the car.

Chapter Two
IN THE ORDER IT CAME OFF

He carried it in by the handle, the way his daddy had carried his, with his arm straight down and the box knocking against his leg on every other step, and by the time he got from the car to the front doors of Brandon Elementary he understood that everybody was looking at him.

Nobody else had a toolbox. Kids had lunch boxes, metal ones with the Dukes of Hazzard on them or Star Wars or Holly Hobbie, and they had book satchels, and some of the girls had little purses with their lunch money in them. Nobody in the history of the fourth grade had ever walked into the building with a red steel toolbox with a lift-out tray, and when Marcus came down the hall to Room 11 with it, a fifth grader he did not know said, "What you gonna do, fix the school?" and two others laughed, and Marcus did not say anything, because he was not altogether sure the answer was no.

Tonya Rankin was already at her desk. She watched him come in.

"Is that a lunch box?" she said.

"No."

"What's in it?"

"Tools."

"What for?"

He did not answer that either. He walked to the back of the room and set the toolbox down under the back table, beside the newspaper with the pencil sharpener laid out on it in a line, which Mrs. Horton had left exactly the way he left it. Nobody had touched it. A janitor could have swept it up, or a kid could have knocked it off, but there it was, pin and crank and screws

and drawer and housing and clip and frame and rollers, every piece where he had set it down, and he understood that she had told somebody to leave it alone.

Mrs. Horton came in with her coffee cup and her pocketbook and set them on her desk. She looked at the back table. She looked at the toolbox under it. She walked down the aisle between the desks, while the class watched her, and she stopped at the back table and looked down at the red lid with the white letters on it, MARCUS ALTON JENNINGS, the whole thing, every letter.

She was quiet for a second longer than she needed to be.

"That's a good box," she said.

"Yes ma'am. My daddy painted it."

"I can see that." She looked at it one more second. "Does it stay under the table?"

"Yes ma'am."

"All right then." And she went back up to the front and picked up the chalk and said, "Good morning. Arithmetic," and everybody groaned, and that was all.

Marcus would think later that if she had made anything of it, if she had said one more word, or asked him one question about his daddy, or looked at him the way Mrs. Pruitt's friends in the hall used to look at him, he would have carried the box straight back out to the parking lot and never brought it again. She did not. She said it was a good box. It was a good box. That was all that needed saying, and she knew it, and she stopped.

⁂

The pick worked.

He got it out at spelling and opened up the first roller and set the bent point of it down into the first groove, and pulled, and a curl of red wax came up out of the steel like a ribbon of candle. He held it up and looked at it. Then he did it again. Every groove ran around the roller in a spiral, like the stripe on a barber pole, and the wax had packed into all of it, and each pull of the pick took out about an inch.

It was going to take forever.

He did the arithmetic in his head while he pulled. The roller was about as big around as his thumb. There were maybe twenty turns of groove on it. Each turn was about three inches around.

That was sixty inches of groove per roller, and two rollers, and an inch a pull. A hundred and twenty pulls, if every pull was clean, which they weren't. He sat back and looked at it and thought that this was the first time in his life long division had ever been good for anything, and then he thought he had better not tell Mrs. Horton that, because she would be too pleased.

He pulled. He pulled through spelling and into reading. Mrs. Horton read the chapter where the boy's dogs tree the coon in the big sycamore, and Marcus pulled red curls out of the steel one at a time and laid them in a little pile on the corner of the newspaper, and he heard every word of it. Behind him the radiator ticked. Dwayne Lofton got up to go to the bathroom and came back the long way, past the back table, and stood there.

"What's that?"

"Crayon."

"Out of the sharpener?"

"Yeah."

Dwayne looked at the pile. "Who put crayon in it?"

"Somebody in summer school."

"Why?"

"To see what it'd do."

Dwayne thought about that. "What'd it do?"

"This," Marcus said, and pulled another curl.

Mrs. Horton said, from the front of the room, without looking up from the book, "Dwayne," in the low voice, and Dwayne went back to his seat. But he looked back twice. And at recess, instead of going out to the swings, he came and stood at the edge of the back table with his hands in his pockets and watched, and after a while he said, "Can I do one," and Marcus looked at him, and at the pick, which was his daddy's, and which nobody had touched in two years but him.

"You got to go slow," he said, and handed it over.

Dwayne went slow. He was terrible at it. He got about a quarter of an inch on his first pull and stabbed the table on his second. But he did a whole groove, all the way around, before the bell, and he held up the curl when it came out like a boy who had caught a fish, and Marcus found he did not mind at all.

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It took four days.

On the second day he figured out the hot water. The wax was hard, and it broke instead of curling, and he had been sitting there thinking about how his mama got candle wax off the tablecloth at Christmas, which was with an iron and a brown paper sack, and he could not bring an iron to school. But the wax would soften with heat. Anything with heat would do it.

He asked to go to the office.

Mrs. Sumrall looked up from her typewriter when he came in and her whole face changed. "Well, look who it is. How's my stapler man?"

"Fine. Mrs. Sumrall, can I have some hot water."

"Hot water."

"Out of the coffee thing in the teachers' lounge. In a cup. For a pencil sharpener."

She looked at him over her glasses for a while.

"Is Mrs. Horton aware that you are getting hot water out of the teachers' lounge for a pencil sharpener?"

"No ma'am. But she gave me the pencil sharpener."

Mrs. Sumrall thought about that, and then she got up, which she did not do for many people, and went down the hall with a Styrofoam cup and came back with it full of water so hot it was steaming, and set it down on the corner of her desk, and said, "Don't you spill that on yourself, and don't you tell anybody where you got it," and he said yes ma'am, and carried it back to Room 11 in both hands the whole way, with his elbows out, like it was full of something alive.

The rollers went in the cup. He let them sit while Mrs. Horton did geography. When he took them out, the wax was soft as butter, and it came out of the grooves in long red-and-green ribbons, two and three inches at a time, and he did half a roller in the time it had taken to do one groove the day before. He used an old toothbrush out of the toolbox, the one his daddy had kept for cleaning battery posts, for the last of it. By the end of the second day the first roller was clean steel, every ridge sharp and bright, and he held it up to the window and turned it and watched the light run along the spiral, and he thought it was the most beautiful thing he had ever made, even though he had not made it at all. He had only got it back to what it was.

Mrs. Horton came down the aisle at lunch and looked at the clean roller in his hand, and at the cup, which was sitting on the newspaper with an inch of cloudy water and a skin of wax in it.

"Where'd you get hot water?"

He did not tell her about Mrs. Sumrall. "I can't say."

She looked at him. Then she did a thing he had never seen her do. She laughed. Not loud. Just once, through her nose, the way a grown person laughs when they did not plan to.

"Well," she said. "Don't spill it."

⁂

On the fourth day he put it back together, and it did not work.

He had both rollers clean. He had the frame clean, and the inside of the housing wiped out with a paper towel, and the drawer emptied of two years of shavings into the trash can. He sat down at the back table at reading time with the newspaper in front of him and the parts in their line, left to right, the way they came off, and he started at the right-hand end and went backward. Rollers on their pins. Pins in the frame. C-clip on the shaft, which took him most of a chapter again and made him say a word under his breath that he had heard at his daddy's shop and was not supposed to know. Frame into the housing. Two halves together. Two screws in the bottom. Drawer in. Crank on. Pin through the crank.

Done.

He picked up a pencil off Dwayne's desk, which by then Dwayne just let him do, and fit it into the hole, and turned the crank.

Nothing.

Not the gravel sound. That was gone. It turned smooth now, quiet, easy, the way a thing turns when it is clean inside. But it did not catch. The pencil came back out of the hole exactly the way it went in.

He sat there. Up front, Mrs. Horton was reading the part where the boy's dog dies, the first one, Old Dan, and the whole room had gone so quiet you could hear the clock, and two of the girls were crying, and Tonya Rankin was crying hardest of anybody, which Marcus would remember about her for the rest of his life and which would change, a little, the way he thought about Tonya Rankin. He heard it. He heard every word. But he sat at the back table with the sharpener in his hands and a feeling going down through him like cold water, because he had done it

all right, every piece, and it did not work, and he did not know why.

He did not take it apart again. Not then. He set it down on the newspaper and put his hands flat on the table on either side of it and looked at it the way he had looked at it the very first day, all the way around, before he ever touched it.

And then he saw it.

The rollers were not the same.

He had thought they were. They had looked the same, two little red-and-green logs side by side. But they weren't. The grooves on one of them went around to the left, and the grooves on the other went around to the right, like two screws with opposite threads, so that when the frame turned they would both be cutting into the pencil, instead of one cutting and one just spinning. He had cleaned them both, and dried them both, and laid them back down on the newspaper side by side, and when he put them back in their pins he had put them back in the wrong pins. The left one on the right. The right one on the left. Each one was turning the wrong way, rolling over the wood instead of biting it.

He had laid them down in order. And then he had picked them up out of order.

He sat there with that for a minute. It was not that it was hard to fix. It would take him five minutes. It was that he had done the one thing, the only rule Mrs. Horton had given him, and he had done it right the whole way until the very end, and at the very end he had let it go, and that was the place it broke.

He took it apart. Pin. Crank. Screws. Drawer. Housing. Clip. Frame. And this time when he got to the rollers, he took the left-hand one off its pin and laid it down on the left, and the right-hand one on the right, and he put his finger on each one and said, out loud, under his breath, "Left. Right," and then he put them back on their own pins, the right way, and closed it all up again, backward, piece by piece.

He picked up Dwayne's pencil.

He fit it into the hole.

He turned the crank.

⁂

Here is the sound a Boston pencil sharpener makes when it is working right. It is not loud. It is a sort of grinding hum, a little rough at first and then smoother as the point comes, and it changes pitch as it goes, so you can tell by the sound alone when the pencil is sharp, without looking. Every person who has ever been in an American schoolroom knows that sound in their bones. It is the sound of the morning starting. It is the sound of somebody in the back getting up out of their seat in the middle of a test to buy themselves thirty more seconds to think.

It had not been heard in Room 11 since the Fourth of July.

It went through the room like a bell. Mrs. Horton stopped reading in the middle of a sentence. Twenty-six heads turned around. And Marcus Jennings sat at the back table with the sharpener in his left hand and the crank in his right, turning it, and he did not stop, because he could not stop, because it was catching, and he could feel it catching all the way up his arm, the little bite of steel in the wood on every turn. And when the sound changed and he knew the pencil was done, he pulled it out and looked at it, and it had a point on it like a needle, perfect, long and clean and even all the way around.

He held it up.

Nobody said anything. Then Dwayne Lofton said, "*Dang*," with real feeling, from two rows up, and Mrs. Horton, who did not allow *dang* in her classroom, let it go.

⁂

She let him put it back on the wall himself.

It was his birthday. He had not told anybody. It was the sixteenth of October and he was nine years old, and he had not told anybody at school because the year before, in Mrs. Pruitt's room, there had been a cupcake for every birthday but his, because nobody had brought one, because his mama had been working, and he had decided right then he was never going to have a birthday at school again. But Mrs. Horton had the birthdays written down in her book. He did not know that. He found out afterward.

She brought her own screwdriver down from her pocketbook. The one with the yellow handle, gone brown where a hand had held it.

"This was my daddy's," she said, and held it out.

He looked at it.

"He was a carpenter," she said. "In Florence. He built half the porches in that town and he couldn't read a newspaper, and he never once in his life apologized for it, and he kept this in his back pocket every day he lived. When he died I took it. I keep it in my pocketbook." She held it a little closer. "You can use it if you're careful."

He took it. It was heavier than it looked. The handle was warm from being in her bag.

He went to the wall by the door, where the two holes were, with the paint gone a little flaky around them, and he held the sharpener up to the holes, and Dwayne Lofton held it level for him without being asked, and Marcus put the first screw in and turned it down, and the second, and the screwdriver caught and bit and held, and the sharpener was on the wall again, solid, where it belonged. He gave the crank one turn, empty, just to hear it hum.

Then he gave the screwdriver back to Mrs. Horton, handle first, the way his daddy had taught him to hand a tool to anybody.

She took it, and put it back in her pocketbook, and then she picked up a pencil off her own desk, a new one, yellow, never sharpened, and walked to the door and put it in the sharpener and turned the crank herself, and the whole class watched her do it. The sound filled the room again. She pulled it out and looked at the point and nodded.

"That," she said, "is a pencil."

And Tonya Rankin started clapping. Nobody told her to. Tonya Rankin, who thought he was something on the bottom of her shoe, sat at her desk with her face still a little puffy from crying over Old Dan and clapped for him, and then Dwayne did, and then the whole room was clapping, and Marcus did not know where to look, so he looked at the floor, and then at the sharpener, and then, finally, at Mrs. Horton.

She was not clapping. She was standing by the door with her new pencil in her hand, looking at him with an expression he would not understand for a great many years, until he had a shop of his own, and a lift and a pegboard and thirty years of other people's problems coming in the door, and saw that same expression on his own face in the window glass, looking at a

nineteen-year-old who had just found out what his hands were for.

"Happy birthday, Marcus," she said.

⁂

She did not send him to the office that whole year. Not one time. She did something else instead, which was that whenever his foot started going and the desk started walking toward the window, she would say, without looking up, "Marcus, the hinge on the coat closet's loose," or "Marcus, that radiator's knocking, see what it wants," or once, in February, "Marcus, Mrs. Sumrall needs you," and he would go, and fix whatever it was, and come back, and sit down, and his foot would be still.

And she said a thing to him in November, on a gray day after school when he was staying late to take apart the classroom record player, that he kept.

"Some people's hands have to be busy for their heads to work," she said. She was grading papers at her desk and did not look up. "My daddy was one. I believe you're one. That isn't a thing wrong with you, Marcus. Anybody tells you it is, they don't know what they're looking at." She marked something on a paper. "It's just how you're built. You don't fight how you're built. You build around it."

He did not say anything. He laid the record player's tone arm down on the rag he'd brought from home, beside the screws, in the order they came off.

⁂

The note came home on his birthday, folded in half in his reading folder. He did not know it was there. His mama found it while he was washing up for supper.

She was at the kitchen table when he came back in. The ironing board was folded and leaned against the pantry, which it never was at six o'clock on a weekday. There was a cake on the counter under a dish towel, a yellow one with chocolate icing out of the can, which was the kind he liked, and he could see the shape of it under the towel and the one candle sticking up through the cloth like a tent pole, and he pretended he did not see it. His mama had the note open in front of her, flat on the table, with her hand on it.

"Sit down," she said.

He sat down.

"You know what this is?"

"No ma'am."

She looked at him. Then she picked up the note and read it to him out loud.

His mama read the way she did everything, slowly and all the way to the end, not skipping anything. She did not read it the way people read a note from school. She read it the way the preacher read Scripture at church, like every word had been put there on purpose by somebody who meant it and ought to be given its full weight.

"*Dear Mrs. Jennings,*" she read. "*I want you to know that today Marcus fixed the pencil sharpener in Room 11, which has been broken since July, and which two men from the district office looked at and could not fix. He took it apart, cleaned it, put it back together, found his own mistake, and fixed that too. He laid every piece down in the order it came off. I have been teaching for eight years and I have never seen a child do that without being shown.*"

She stopped. She looked at the page for a second, and then she went on.

"*He has been called a lot of things in this building. I would like you to know what I call him. I call him a mechanic. Happy birthday to him. Yours truly, Delores Horton.*"

She set the note down.

Neither of them said anything. Down the hall the radio was on, low, the way she always left it. Outside, a car went by on Sherwood Drive with its windows down and the ball game on.

"Your daddy did that," his mama said.

He looked at her.

"Laid it out in order. Every time. Every part he ever took off of anything." She was looking at the note, not at him. "He'd lay a rag down on the bench, and every bolt and every washer and every little piece would go down on it in a line, left to right, in the order it came off. I used to fuss at him. I had to wash those rags, and they'd come home black, and I'd say, Alton, why can't you just put them in a coffee can like a normal man. And he'd say, *Dora Lee, a coffee can doesn't remember anything.*" She smoothed the note flat with one finger. "Nobody showed you that. You weren't but seven. You never saw him do it but a handful of times."

Marcus sat there.

He had not known. He had thought it was his. He had thought it was a thing he had come up with, the line on the newspaper, the order, the sentence you could read backward. And it was his. But it had been somebody's first. It had been his daddy's, on a rag in a shop on a Saturday, and it had gone into Marcus without anybody putting it there, the way the smell of the shop had gone into the toolbox and waited.

Gone is different from not coming, his mama had told him once. On a cold morning, in a truck, outside a lawyer's office. *Gone means he'd be here if the Lord allowed it.*

He thought he understood a little more of what she meant.

His mama folded the note back in half, along its crease, and then in half again. She did not give it back to him. She opened her pocketbook, which was on the chair beside her, and put the note in the inside pocket with the zipper, where she kept the things she kept, and zipped it closed.

Then she got up and took the dish towel off the cake.

"Well," she said. "You going to blow this out or not?"

⁂

He kept the toolbox under the back table in Room 11 for the rest of the fourth grade, and nobody ever touched it, and at the end of May he carried it home, and it never went back in the hall closet again.

It went to Brandon Junior High with him, and to Brandon High, where in the ninth grade a skinny loud boy named Earl Henderson, who sat beside him in Mr. Cauthen's class because of the alphabet, looked at the white letters on the lid and said, "Man, who paints their *whole name* on a toolbox," and Marcus said, "My daddy did," and Earl was quiet for a second, and then said, "Well, he spelled it right," and that was the beginning of that.

It went with him to his first job and his first shop. It is in the front office of Rankin County Auto Repair right now, on the shelf over the coffee maker, retired, with the paint worn down to bare steel on the corners and the *J* still a little rough where the brush went over it twice. Nobody uses it. Everything in it is too small for him now. But every morning at ten after six, before the coffee, before the lights, he walks past it, and some mornings he puts his hand on the lid.

And he still lays the parts out on a clean rag, left to right, in the order they come off, every single time. His wife used to fuss at him about the rags, back when he had a wife.

And once a year, give or take, an old woman in a Buick the color of weak tea pulls into his lot, and parks crooked, and does not walk into his work, because she has a policy about that. And he wipes his hands and goes to her.

"Morning, Mrs. Horton."

"Marcus."

She has never once called him Mac.

ABOUT THE McLEARN MEDIA SERIES

Mac Jennings grows up to run Rankin County Auto Repair, and to find out what a forty-one-page contract can do to a man who reads every word of it, in *The Accidental Executive*. He comes back to the lawyer's office on Capitol Street, and to the paper his father left behind, in *The Highway 80 Ledger*.

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